Human-made Things in the Bible © United Bible Societies, 2025. Adapted from: The Works of Their Hands: Man-made Things in the Bible, by Ray Pritz © 2009 United Bible Societies. This work is licensed under Creative Commons Attribution-ShareAlike 4.0 International (https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-sa/4.0/).

Necklace, chain, cord

10.5.4 Necklace, chain, cord

References:

Aramaic הַמְנִיךְ (hamnik) DAN 5:7, DAN 5:7, DAN 5:16, DAN 5:16, DAN 5:29, DAN 5:29

Hebrew חָרוּז (charuzim) SNG 1:10

Hebrew כּוּמָז (kumaz) EXO 35:22, NUM 31:50

Hebrew נְטִיפָה (netifah) JDG 8:26, ISA 3:19

Hebrew עָנָק, ענק (ʻanaq (noun or verb)) JDG 8:26, PSA 73:6, PRO 1:9, SNG 4:9

Hebrew פָּתִיל (pathil) GEN 38:18, GEN 38:25

Hebrew רָבִיד (ravid) GEN 41:42, EZK 16:11

Hebrew שַׁהֲרוֹן (saharonim) JDG 8:26, ISA 3:18

Greek μανιάκης (maniakēs) 1ES 3:6

Description and usage:

Necklaces (© Wolfgang Sauber, CC BY-SA 3.0, via Wikimedia Commons)The necklace was a string, band, cord, or chain worn around the neck for ornamentation. Often jewels or other ornaments were attached to it.

Translation:

GEN 41:42; DAN 5:7; DAN 5:16; DAN 5:29: In these passages a chain of gold is given by a ruler to someone who has been promoted to a high position. The chain in both contexts was probably more substantial than a simple necklace, and it will be better to use a word meaning "chain" rather than one referring to a thin decorative necklace. However, it is important to include in the translation something indicating honor or high rank and not slavery. In some languages a word exists for a symbol of honor or high office that is worn around the neck. Where such a word does not exist or is obscure, the element of honor may be included by expanding the translation; for example, GNT has "chain of honor" in DAN 5:7.

According to some commentators, the Aramaic word *hamnik* in DAN 5:7; DAN 5:16; DAN 5:29 does not actually refer to a chain but rather to a solid metal collar. NAB has "collar." In some languages a single verb can be used for wearing purple clothing and the golden collar as symbols of authority. But in others it will be more natural to use two separate verbs for "wearing" clothing and for "wearing" an ornament like a chain or collar around the neck.

SNG 1:10: The Hebrew word *charuz* (plural, *charuzim*) actually means a small bead or gem with a hole in it. When many of these were stung onto a string, they formed a necklace. Some translations render *charuzim* as "necklaces" (NJB, PV), while others prefer to speak about the "jewels" (GNT, NCV) or "precious stones" that made up the necklaces. Others combine the two: RSV "strings of jewels"; NASB "strings of beads"; CEV "necklace of precious stones"; and SPCL "pearl necklaces."

The meaning of the Hebrew word *kumaz* (EXO 35:22; NUM 31:50) is uncertain, but it clearly refers to some kind of jewelry. Most translations agree that it indicates something that was worn around the neck, whether "necklaces" (GNT, GECL) or "pendants" (REB, NJPSV).

GEN 38:18; GEN 38:25: In these verses the Hebrew word *pathil* probably refers to nothing more than a simple cord around the neck, used to hold the signet ring. CEV is good with "cord around your neck" in EXO 30:25.

For the Hebrew words *netifah* and *saharonim*, see the discussion on ISA 3:18–ISA 3:23 under 10.5 Jewelry, ornaments<REALIA:10.5>.